

2.4b (15 marks): How do descent theories and alliance theories differ, same-sex marriage challenges kinship system:

Descent and Alliance theories are two ways to understand kinship & social organization.

Descent Theory

- * By Structural-Functionalist.
- * Says descent rules determine kinship and social organization.
- * Have 6 types of descent -
 - Unilineal
 - Bi-lineal
 - Bi-lateral
 - Ambilineal.
 - etc.
- * Says Unilineal descent is main types of descent determining kinship.
- * Ignores importance of marriage in kinship.

Alliance Theory

- * By Levi Strauss, as a reaction to Descent theories
- * Says Marriage alliance, between two groups, from generation to generation, gives rise to kinship.
- * Exchange of women between groups lead to creation of alliance, hence

strengthening their survival.

* Hence incest-taboo is critical aspect.

Impact of same-sex-marriage:

- 1> It defies traditional definition of marriage.
ie - Marriage as a union between a man and a woman, by Westermarck
- 2> Changes nomenclature.
eg. In Male-Male marriage, both are called "husbands".
- 3> Acceptance of sperm-donor/egg-donor to raise a family.
- 4> Challenging traditional gender roles.

Hence same-sex marriage brings individual choices at front, while also showing society's growing tolerance towards them.